The world's interest in the BRICs continued. In the mid-2000s, O'Neill (with Robert Hormats)[5] supported the inclusion of China in an overhaul of global governance institutions such as the G7 and the G20. O'Neill frequently suggested that these large, non-Western governments needed to be integrated into the top international policymakers, as they were starting to surpass many G7 economies, whose leaders still behaved as though they dominated the world.[6]

Nonetheless, the new BRICs club, almost from the outset, encountered bewildered skepticism, even derision, from Western observers, including both officials and academics. Each of the member-states had its detractors, while the collective group was also frequently dismissed as an unworkable gimmick. Most experts predicted the BRICS' rapid demise, especially given the heterogeneous characteristics of the group, which unites two authoritarian regimes and three democracies (following South Africa's incorporation in December 2010, when it became known as BRICS), three commodity exporters and two purchasers of raw materials, and at least one country, Brazil, with no historic ties to any of the others. The group also became increasingly lopsided, as China's economic growth dwarfed the others and it rose in 2010 to become the second-largest economy in the world. In 2016, India began growing faster than China; but even if India's very rapid growth continues, it will take a few more decades before New Delhi can expect to rival the current world leaders, even in the most optimistic scenarios.

Despite these differences and doubts, however, the BRICS did not fold. What attracted these disparate countries to form a new diplomatic club, and what explains their sustained enthusiasm for expanding the scope of joint BRICS activities? Does the ongoing global power shift signify the waning of unipolarity and the "rise of the rest"[7] in a new multipolar structure that particularly benefits the BRICS, or is this mostly a China story? Do the BRICS possess sufficient material means and political commitment to achieve their stated objectives? Given its predominance within the BRICS club, why is China interested in cooperating with the other members if it can affect the global system just as well by acting unilaterally? Why do the other four BRICS choose to go along with China? These are key questions addressed in this volume.